

Reflection on My Website Project

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When I first started the project, the problem description existed only in natural language. I wanted to build a simple website about five native fish species found in Pennsylvania and include basic information, images, and a few interactive elements. To convert this English description into functional HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, I broke the idea into smaller tasks. For example, the instruction “show a picture of a spawning Mountain Redbelly Dace with its description next to it” became a set of HTML elements such as `<img>`, `<h2>`, and `<p>`. After structuring the content in HTML, I used CSS to organize the layout and make the page visually appealing. Finally, I used JavaScript to add interactive features like buttons and hover effects.

While building the website, I encountered several bugs that I had to resolve. One of the first issues was that none of my images were loading. I checked the code several times before realizing that the problem was caused by an incorrect file path. Instead of writing:

```

```

I needed to use:

```

```

Once I corrected the file path, the images appeared properly.

Another bug was semantic: the code ran, but it did not behave the way I intended. I had written a small JavaScript function to display a message when the user hovered over a fish photo. Even though no errors appeared, the message was never displayed. Eventually, I discovered that I used the wrong capitalization in an ID name. My JavaScript referenced:

```
document.getElementById("infoBox")
```

but my HTML contained:

```
<div id="infobox">
```

The capital “B” was enough to break the entire script. Once I changed the JavaScript to match the exact ID, the function worked correctly. This helped me understand how precise and literal code must be.

Some parts of the project were fun to create. One of my favorite features was designing the citizen science tool so people could submit fish to the PA Fish and Boat Commission. A little easter egg I left in was making the Musky image super small, so people who do not fish might think it is just a tiny fish that does not get big.

My project is based on a personal passion: native fish species. The website provides basic information on how to identify each species, along with simple ecological facts. I worked alone on this project, and I had almost no coding experience before this class, aside from brief exposure to Scratch in high school.

As a consumer of content presented through algorithms, I already had concerns about technology before starting the class. Reading *Filterworld* intensified these concerns. I was already uncomfortable with social media algorithms and how they aim to keep users on platforms for as long as possible. What I had not considered before this course was the secondhand effect: when content creators shape their work to suit algorithms instead of human audiences, culture becomes less genuine. Algorithmic curation shifts creativity toward generic, repetitive content rather than unique human expression.

If I could give advice to developers, I would encourage them to question whether their algorithms improve actual user experience or simply increase user engagement time. Since so much human communication now occurs through digital platforms, code determines what information people see and how they interact with one another. At the same time, code has limitations. It can reflect the biases of the people who create it, and it can only follow the instructions it is given. If the underlying design is flawed, the code cannot “fix itself.” Some limitations of my own website come from my beginner skill level. For example, my layout is simple, some pages are not fully responsive on mobile devices, and my JavaScript effects are basic.

I decided to build my website in the because I thought showing people the most common and popular fish in Pennsylvania could then lead to them being curious about the other fish that can be found in PA. I also did because it matched my skill level and allowed me to apply the concepts we practiced throughout the semester. In conclusion, reading *Filterworld* increased my concerns about the cultural effects of algorithms, and building my website helped me understand how code shapes online experiences.

References

Google. (2024). *Gemini* [Large language model]. <https://ai.google.dev/gemini>
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GitHub. (2026). *Final project repository*: <https://eliwisor.github.io/finalproj/>